

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Crime, thriller

DIRECTOR

Quentin Tarantino

WRITERS

Quentin Tarantino, Roger Avary (story); Quentin Tarantino (script)

STARS

John Travolta, Samuel L. Jackson, Uma Thurman, Bruce Willis

BEFORE

1955 Noir thriller *Kiss Me Deadly* features a glowing suitcase that's thought to have inspired the one in *Pulp Fiction*.

AFTER

1997 Similarly to *Pulp Fiction*, Tarantino's *Jackie Brown* weaves together a large cast and many plot elements.

2003 Revenge romp *Kill Bill* sees Tarantino elevating Uma Thurman to a blood-soaked starring role.

In the early 1990s, a movie fanatic and video-store clerk named Quentin Tarantino, originally from Knoxville, Tennessee, had a seismic impact on American movies. Although the likes of Richard Linklater and Spike Lee had brought exciting new ideas to American cinema, it had been a long time since it had felt dangerous. Tarantino relocated to Southern California, and his debut as the director of *Reservoir Dogs* felt very dangerous indeed—a foul-mouthed, blood-soaked crime story that was also incredibly funny. Two years later, Tarantino followed up with



Pulp Fiction, which kept up the verbal zing of its predecessor but also introduced a dazzlingly inventive structure and A-list Hollywood stars.

Tarantino's profane, freewheeling style was like an adrenaline shot to the heart—a motif that would appear in *Pulp Fiction*. Part of what made him such a novelty was his approach to genre. Just as *Reservoir Dogs* had reimagined the heist movie, so *Pulp Fiction* took the conventions of the B-movie—a gangland killing, a boxer taking a dive, and a hitman in search of redemption—and repurposed them in new, brilliantly knowing ways. The result has the stylistic charge of a genre movie while remaining a genuinely original and innovative movie experience.

Structural shift

One of the iconic elements of *Pulp Fiction* is its use of nonlinear storytelling. By fracturing the narrative, Tarantino does not allow the audience to settle into the traditional rhythms of watching »

Vincent Vega (John Travolta) pairs up with Mia Wallace (Uma Thurman) at Jack Rabbit Slim's for some comically clichéd dance moves.

Minute by minute

